IV—The Fist

> ‘On the completion of my twentieth year, I experienced an internal bitterness . . . my soul was seized with exceeding sorrow.’
>
> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

Some eight months after Bairam’s murder, his son, Abdur Rahim, was returned to court, and Akbar adopted him. It was September 1561; Abdur Rahim was just short of five years old, and Akbar of nineteen. In a painting of the scene, Abdur Rahim is being taught how to bow to the padishah, who reaches out to him, one hand resting on the boy’s back, the other taking one of his little hands into his own.[1] Given the aesthetic conventions of medieval and pre-modern art, Abdur Rahim has a rather adult face; you might even say that it is Akbar who looks the younger of the two.

The emperor would be fully grown by now, though he was never very tall; even Abul Fazl admits Akbar was ‘of middle height’.[2] But he was strong; it was only months earlier that he had killed a lioness single-handed, and months later that he would knock a man to the ground with a single blow. Even so, though later visitors would describe Akbar as broad-shouldered and ‘exceedingly well-built’,[3] for the moment he appears rather slight, his frame not quite full, and hints of boyishness in his small, round face, with its wisp of a moustache.

There is nothing childlike about his expression, however; instead, an ageless tenderness fills his eyes. He knew what it was to lose a father; and now, in fact, a father figure, too. In the fifteen-odd months after Bairam Khan’s death, Akbar would lose a great deal more, besides: friends and faith in his administrators, his shyness of shedding human blood, and, worst of all, the privilege to shrug off the burdens of rule.

It began with the blood-soaked conquest of Malwa.

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Malwa, which corresponds roughly to western Madhya Pradesh today, was then ruled by Baz Bahadur, who enjoys a historical reputation on two counts – his talent for composing Hindi songs[4] and his love for Rupmati, ‘renowned throughout the world for her beauty and charm’,[5] for whom, in